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INDISCIPLINE IN SENIOR HIGH SCHOOLS IN GHANA

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ABSTRACT

The study investigated causes and influence of indiscipline in secondary schools in Ghana. A multi-site case study from a population of students, teachers, headmasters, headmistresses, assistance heads, senior housemasters and mistresses and parents was adopted. A sample size of 56 participants, comprising 10 school prefects, 10 non prefects, 5 house staff and 15 parents were engaged in a focus group discussion. In addition, 8 headmaster/mistresses, and 8 senior housemasters/ mistresses were interviewed. The data analysis method used was thematic. The study which is in its first phase, was conducted in Southern Ghana. The study revealed three key causes of school indiscipline, namely, attitude of parents over protecting their wards even when school rules were flouted, the interpretation the media ascribed to indiscipline and the removal of corporal punishment from disciplinary actions. The study also revealed that indiscipline lowered the authorities of school leaders and teachers and led to a declined in students' academic performance. The study therefore recommended an alternative disciplinary regime which should include sanctions to be collectively agreed upon by student unions, civil society organizations, law enforcement officers, educational institutions, parents and religious bodies.

Introduction and Study Context

Over the past decade, there has been increasing spate of indiscipline in Ghana. Standards of behaviour, attitudes, norms, and values in society have changed over the past decade, especially among the youth (Chimhenga, 2017). Thoughts, attitudes and norms of young learners are continuously evolving and changing negatively. Particularly, in senior high schools, there have been reports of students' negative behavioural issues. Indeed, the issue of students' behavioural problems remains a challenge for many parents, social workers, teachers, educationists and significant others who are concerned with the education of the youth. Indiscipline affects teaching and learning, so it cannot be ignored by well-meaning stakeholders in education. It is important that educational leaders understand the effect of such behaviours and provide policy direction for national education development (Chimhenga, 2017; Asiedu-Yirenkyi, 2019).

In classroom learning situations, some learners have lost respect for their teachers and disturbed the learning activities by making unnecessary noise and bullying fellow learners (Chimhenga, 2017). Ngwokabuenui (2015) observed that these students cultivate and demonstrate deviant behaviours and may not fulfill their potentials. As a result there is an outcry of Cameroonian educators, administrators and parents about the increasing rate of indiscipline in Cameroonian secondary schools. Some young people have resorted to delinquency and drug abuse. These changes are common in most societies, including Ghana. Such changes affect attitudes of young and old people. Chimhenga (2017) argues that the norms and values within the society are changing, and these changes affect upbringing of children. This trend of indiscipline among young people "unsettles the mind of patriotic Cameroonians since children are considered the future leaders of the country" (Ngwokabuenui, 2015, p.64)

There have been countless number of incidences in schools where students have threatened teachers, molested them, and abused them for example, there has been a case of female students in school uniforms sighted for indecent behaviours on school compound in Ghana, and even threatening teachers. Again, there was a social media report of some female students raining insults on government official of the country, (Asare-Donkoh, 2018). In another instance, Ghanaians were horrified to hear a case of indiscipline from groups of senior high school (SHS) examination candidates who stated that because the first paper they wrote, *Integrated Science,* was too difficult for them, they carried out riot, vandalism, and insulted authorities. Some of these SHS students attacked and assaulted journalists, teachers who invigilated them, heads of school, and other West African Examination Council (WAEC) officials. This is quite disturbing as a nation. It must be emphasized that these acts of indiscipline among students have become a national concern (https://www.graphic.com.gh/news/general-news/wassce-bright-shs-students-beat-invigilator-graphic-reporter).

The Ghana Education Service and the Ministry of Education, in conjunction with other stakeholders such as the Ghana National Association of Teachers (GNAT), and National Association of Graduate Teachers (NAGRAT) have developed rules and regulations, and measures such as institutionalizing the Guidance and Counselling Unit in SHS to curb the menace of indiscipline in SHSs in Ghana. Yet, indiscipline persists in SHSs. Predicated on the unabated occurrences of indiscipline, especially in SHSs, despite efforts at the institutional and national levels, the literature (Amoah, et al., 2015) gives indication that an in-depth inquiry to gauge the experiences of key stakeholders (school administrators, teachers, parents, students and significant others) is needed. Therefore, this study sets out to investigate the causal factors accounting for indiscipline in senior high schools. These issues provided the *raison d'être* for the study.

Purpose and Objectives

The study intended to bring the issues of student indiscipline to the fore of national discussions sthrough disseminating the findings from this research with the aim of providing direction for a national policy on discipline in schools, a policy that will be relevant in keeping the Ghanaian social order.

The following objectives were formulated to guide the study:

a. To Identify the causes and effects of students' indiscipline in secondary schools in Ghana:
    a. School-based factors that cause indiscipline at the secondary schools.

b. Societal-based factors that cause indiscipline in the secondary schools.

b. To establish the influence of school indiscipline on nation building in Ghana.

c. To evolve alternative policy direction and measures to curb school indiscipline in SHSs in Ghana.

Methodology

Qualitative research approach, utilising the multi-site case study design was employed. The population comprised of students, teachers, headmasters/mistresses and assistants, senior house masters, house masters and mistresses, and parents. The sample frame covered students, teachers, headmasters and assistants, senior house masters, house masters and mistresses and parents The sample included 40 participants who were interviewed. In addition, 10 school prefects, 10 non-prefects, 5 house staff and 5 parents were engaged in a focus group discussion. A pilot testing was conducted at the Winneba Senior High School which was not included in the study sample. The aim of the pilot testing was to identify any ambiguities in the questions and to fine tune the items. In addition, to ensure trustworthiness of the question items, member checking was used to determine accuracy of the instruments (Creswell, 2009; Amoah et al., 2015).

The data analysis method used was thematic. To ensure anonymity, the respondents were identified with codes per the category (e.g. School head (HM), assistant head academic (AHA), assistant domestic (AHD), prefects (Prefects), non-prefects (non-Prefects, school counsellors (GCC) etc). Under the first research objective, to identify the causes of school indiscipline among SHS students in Ghana, the themes identified were school based factors which included rushed policies (e.g. abolishment of corporal punishment), students capitalising on child rights/codes of conduct thus, neglecting the responsibility factor, peer pressure, misbehaviour of new teachers due to indiscipline imbibed from their alma mater and teachers' limited knowledge of child rights/code of conduct. The themes identified under the societal-based factors included problem with media/child rights activist groups' negative parental influence.

The second research objective (to establish the effects of school indiscipline in Senior High Schools in Ghana) the themes identified included, loss of teacher authority, poor academic performance, irresponsible future leadership, increase rate of social vices, danger to national peace and development, and social/ physical attacks on teachers.

The third research objective identification of alternative measures to curb school indiscipline in Ghana, themes such as strong but regulated sanctions, sensitization through the media, media restrictions, education through the religious bodies, motivating teachers/encouraging teacher discipline, reinstitution of the Parent Association regime, and review of GES discipline codes.

FINDINGS

Objective One: To identify causes of school indiscipline among SHS students in Ghana.

Theme One: School-Based Factors

Although there are myriads of causes accounting for indiscipline in schools, especially at the SHS level, school-based factors were major theme identified. (Asiedu-Yirenkyi, 2019). Participants, who included Assistant Headmaster, House staff, school-prefects and non-school prefects, provided responses during fieldwork. Out of the school-based factors, two sub themes emerged, abolishment of corporal punishment and teacher misbehaviour

Sub theme one: The Abolishment of Corporal Punishment in school

In relation to the abolishment of corporal punishment in schools, an assistant head for academic affairs observed:

> *I will say that in a way the abolishment of corporal punishment has not totally helped… we are used to being disciplined by the cane for many years. Taking out the cane and other corporal punishment made people do not really care especially in these days of human rights* (AHA#2).

Another assistant head for domestic activities remarked:

> *In fact, with the abolishment of corporal punishment students have become untouchable as if they were kings and queens, and because of that it has promoted indiscipline to the highest level. Some of the children know that because of this child right thing, they are not to be given corporal punishment. And so, because of this, the children take the law into their own hands. They come to school late and disrespect teachers* (AHD# 2).

In addition to the interview, participants (non-prefects) were involved in a focus group. Excerpts:

- The President of Ghana says you cannot cane me, so I have the right to report if you cane me.
- One thing we need to do is to show evidence or mark of caning on the body.
- The nation itself is derailing on indiscipline especially people in authority. This is reflected in our schools.
- The removal of caning has made indiscipline very high.

In another focus group session, participants (Prefects) voiced out the following sentiments (excerpts):

- Lashing is no more, so we have indiscipline very high.
- Regarding societal factors, indiscipline is so widespread that years to come, you cannot even talk about your own children without someone or a child telling you I will arrest you.
- Indiscipline in our secondary schools is based on this domestic violence thing. Before a person becomes a mom or a woman, she thinks it is normal to beat another person.
- The children are taking advantage of the fact that we cannot cane them. They know that all we can do is to talk.

The data reveal that with the introduction and abolishment of corporal punishment in schools students are free to behave the way they deem fit regardless of the rules and regulations of the schools. Students feel that they cannot be punished because they are protected by the Child's Rights Act. This has given students the freedom to misbehave in schools and also take the law into their own hands. This state of affairs has promoted high indiscipline in secondary schools in Ghana. This finding corroborate the view of Ngwokabuenui (2015, p. 65) who observed that "students have become uncontrollable and highly disrespectful to; teachers, school administrators, parents and the society at large".

Sub-theme Two; Increasing enrollment without corresponding facilities in dormitories and classrooms

During an interview session a Guidance and Counselling Coordinator had this to say,

> *Student numbers are very high and makes discipline difficult. The intake is too much as compared to the number of teachers in the school. Most of our students get frustrated with the food they are offered; girls are breaking bounds because conditions in the dormitories are terrible* (GCC# 5).

Again, a Senior House staff commented thus,

> *We are over recruiting students, but our facilities remain the same over the years. Classrooms are clouded with large numbers being admitted. Our dormitories are worse. These residential facilities were built to accommodate certain number of students but now we have exceeded and overflowing. These conditions give vent to student misbehaviour such as stealing items from their friends, wanting to go and sleep at their boy friends' place, which is more comfortable, and joining gangs in town* (SNH#3)

Narratives from both the interviews and the focus group discussions signified the out-rushed abolition of corporal punishment and students capitalizing on child's right/code as the key cause of student indiscipline in Senior High Schools. The debate relating to the removal of corporal punishment or the arguments regarding its reintroduction will linger on for a long time to come. What is not in doubt, however, is that in Ghana, there is a great concern at the moment relating to what is seen as the collapse of moral values at personal, community and national levels, and this has transcended into schools. The state of school facilities relating to the classrooms and dormitories is critical to stemming student indiscipline. If conditions in the dormitories is deplorable it may promote truancy among students. Cases of students breaking bounds, running to town and others must be a matter of concern to stakeholders. It is recommended that the government of Cameroon, policy makers, education reformers, and school administrators should ensure that schools are provided with adequate facilities for teaching and learning, sports and games as well as information communication technologies and internet connectivity (Blandina and Leonce, 2021; Asiyai, 2005; & Ngwokabuenui, 2015). A second strand to the argument is what Chimhenga (2017) refers to as the battle to control the child. This battle is pitched among four actors: the child, the school, the parents and human rights groups. Each of these constituents has a different perception about how the child is to be brought under control as it relates to moral standards. Implicitly, unless there is a common understanding regarding how a child is to be groomed as a responsible citizen of society, the canker of indiscipline especially in our Senior High Schools, will continue to persist. Bear (2008) posits that schools fail to recognise that behaviour correction is not a sufficient prerequisite for developing self-discipline. Effective establishment and maintenance of safety and order in schools and other institutions do not always translate into the development of self-discipline or the avoidance of future behavioural issues. According to the author, the main methods for controlling behaviour are consistent incentives, unambiguous guidelines and expectations, and penalties for bad behaviours. This position sits well with Aguba (2009) who maintained that discipline is externally induced in individuals who do not succumb to established rules and regulations out of personal volition but out of fear of punishment or sanctions.

Sub Theme Two: Misbehaviour of teachers

Also, generated from the field as school-based factor accounting for indiscipline in senior high schools was misbehaviour of teachers.